

partition with around 250 MB of the disk space allocated as a swap partition.

We suggest that you stick to 'Auto allocate' if you are new to creating and resizing partitions. Also remember, once you are past this screen there is no way to change your partitions or the disk on which you want to install Mandrake. You will have to reset and start all over again. So make sure you choose the right options



Choose the partition in which you want to install Mandrake

the first time around. If you are planning to make custom partitions, then as a rule of thumb the swap partition should be twice the size of the RAM installed on your PC. Selecting critical applications: Once you are through with setting partitions, Mandrake will present you with a screen listing different applications. Here you can select all the applications that you would like to install with the OS. Make sure you select applications such as KOffice 1.1.1 (an integrated office suite that includes a word processor and spreadsheet), GIMP (an image editing software), XMMS (a multimedia player), and Game station. Make sure to check the Configuration

button, which will later help you configure your system for Internet access.

Once you've selected all the packages you need, click on 'Install'. The amount of time the installation will take depends on your system. Generally, it takes not more than 30 minutes on a decently powered machine with the kind of packages that we have described. If you select all the applications listed on the screen, then you will need approximately 1.23 GB of disk space. Creating user accounts: Once the installation is complete, Mandrake will prompt you to create a new root password. It will then prompt you to create a new user account and assign a name and password for it.

GUI options: After you've created a user account, you will be prompted for the default user and the default Windows manager to be used the first time Mandrake boots. The first user account created will be displayed by default along with KDE as the default Windows manager.

Configuring a Network card/modem: Mandrake 8.2 will automatically detect the network card or modem, whichever is installed on your machine, and will prompt you for further configuration settings. If you have trouble configuring your modem or network card here, then you can configure it once Mandrake is setup. Double-click on the Control Center shortcut on the desktop and configure using the 'Networking and Internet' tab.

Supply the necessary IP address, DNS settings, subnet masks, proxy settings or host name, dial-up number and login/password or any modem strings that you may choose to use. Once you have entered the information, Mandrake will test the settings and connection. If all goes well, it will display a message of successful configuration. Other peripherals: Mandrake will now display some of the devices that are connected to the PC, such as a PS/2 mouse, keyboard, soundcard, printer, etc. You can change, add or configure more devices on this screen.



Select applications as per your individual needs

Before you Install

- If you are planning to install Mandrake on a system that already has Windows on it, backup all the data before you proceed.
- In the BIOS disable Plug and Play before you begin installing Mandrake 8.2. If this feature is not disabled, Mandrake might not detect some of the hardware properly.
- Note down names of peripherals installed on the machine and the IRQ settings. There is very little chance of Mandrake asking for any of this information, but then you never know when you might need this critical piece of information.
- To uninstall Mandrake 8.2 completely from the system, don't directly use FDISK. Instead, boot the machine from the Mandrake 8.2 CD and proceed to disk partitioning just the way you did during installation. Now delete only the Linux partition. Your machine will no longer contain any remnants of Linux. Be very careful here and don't delete the FAT partition, else Windows will also get deleted.

The user interface

Mandrake 8.2 boots with KDE 2.2.2 as the default graphical user interface and integrates the dramatically improved KOffice 1.1.1 office suite. Mandrake also comes with GNOME 1.4.1 along with Evolution 1.0.2 (a tool for personal and workgroup information management) and Nautilus 1.0.6 (file manager for the GNOME desktop). Mandrake now also bundles Supermount, which provides transparent access to removable media such as CD-ROMs and floppy disks to all applications. On a Pentium III 700e with 192 MB RAM, we found the user interface to be a little sluggish. The desktop is very simple to understand but it is advisable to spend sometime with the OS and read about it in the Help section before making any changes to the default setting.

The interface is quite easy to get accustomed to and the typical Windows user will not have too much trouble getting used to it. The Control Center, with its eye-catching icons, is almost similar to the Control Panel in Windows. The Control Center does not let you in without entering the root password. This protects your computer's settings by not letting